open for conversions by people who decried Hinduism as 'hopeless[ly] idolatrous'.[30]

ABVKA's work in Jashpur came to be indirectly linked to this debate when President Prasad visited Surguja (another former princely state near Jashpur) to see two new colonies for forest-dwellers built as a pilot scheme. There he met locals, some of whom seemed to have complained about conversions. A newspaper account of this meeting reported that 'nearly 300,000 people are stated to have been converted during the last few years' in Raigarh, Surguja and neighbouring districts. Many missionaries countered that they were being unfairly maligned. Their work, they said, was being tarnished by communal propagandists.[31] Prasad leaned into the raging debate, issuing two public statements on conversions in 1954. Speaking in open forums, the president said that India guaranteed full freedom to preach Christianity, but warned churches that 'none' of their activities should be inspired by a desire for conversion.[32] In Mysore, he told church groups in a public meeting to 'avoid activities which cause suspicion'.[33] This hysteria over foreign missionaries arose at a time when their numbers had almost doubled after independence, to 4,683 (1947–1952) compared with 2,271 (1942–1947).[34]

India's encounter with Christianity can be traced back to the arrival of Saint Thomas the Apostle, who is said to have reached Kerala's Malabar coast in 52 CE.[35] There was a second phase when the first Protestant missionaries (from Germany) arrived in the Danish colony of Tranquebar on the Coromandel coast in 1706,[36] and a third phase under the British, who introduced 'prohibitory measures against Christian missionaries' and drastically reduced state subsidies to them after the 1857 Uprising because 'aggressive' proselytising by Evangelicals was seen as one of the causes of the upsurge.[37] Now, independent India was all astir on the issue of proselytisation. This was also the time when Nehru was formulating what came to be known as his Tribal Panchsheel Policy, influenced by the anthropologist Verrier Elwin, which broadly aimed to protect the cultures of various Indian tribes and ring-fence them from too many outside interventions.